

I THINK MYSELF HAPPY!

Psalms 144:9-15

TEXT: [Acts 26:1-3](#) *"Then Agrippa said unto Paul, Thou art permitted to speak for thyself. Then Paul stretched forth the hand, and answered for himself: ²I think myself happy, king Agrippa, because I shall answer for myself this day before thee touching all the things whereof I am accused of the Jews: ³Especially because I know thee to be expert in all customs and questions which are among the Jews: wherefore I beseech thee to hear me patiently."*

1 Peter 1:13 *"Wherefore gird up the loins of your mind, be sober, and hope to the end for the grace that is to be brought unto you at the revelation of Jesus Christ;"*

INTRO: In the Twenty Sixth chapter of the book of Acts we find the Apostle Paul standing before Agrippa about to answer questions concerning his behavior within the religious community. He has been accused of all kinds of blasphemous acts when in reality there was absolutely no evidence to support the charges! In a very short period of time Paul has gone from being a rising star, to being a shooting star! In religious politics, that's not as hard to do as you might think!

Paul has been arrested and tried by the legal religious authorities of his day, and because no one can find anything within his character worthy of prison or death, they pass him around like a political hot potato, hoping someone will have enough courage to convict him without evidence! We hear stories of people wrongly convicted, incarcerated, and sometimes executed and we are absolutely taken back by such things. This kind of things happens in religious circles far more often than it happens in the world!

While Paul was in Ephesus for his final time he spoke of his incarceration in this manner: [Acts 20:22-23](#) *"And now, behold, I go bound in the spirit unto Jerusalem, not knowing the things that shall befall me there: ²³Save that the Holy Ghost witnesseth in every city, saying that bonds and afflictions abide me."*

Paul had every opportunity to become angry, and develop a sour attitude. **2 Cor. 11:23-28** *"...I have worked much harder, been in prison more frequently, been flogged more severely, and been exposed to death again and again. ²⁴Five times I received from the Jews the forty lashes minus one. ²⁵Three times I was beaten with rods, once I was stoned, three times I was shipwrecked, I spent a night and a day in the open sea, ²⁶I have been constantly on the move. I have been in danger from rivers, in*

danger from bandits, in danger from my own countrymen, in danger from Gentiles; in danger in the city, in danger in the country, in danger at sea; and in danger from false brothers. ²⁷I have labored and toiled and have often gone without sleep; I have known hunger and thirst and have often gone without food; I have been cold and naked. ²⁸Besides everything else, I face daily the pressure of my concern for all the churches."

Would these problems be enough to cause you to be discouraged or quit? Would they make you "UNHAPPY"? Listen to what Paul has to say about it! [Acts 20:24](#) *"But none of these things move me, neither count I my life dear unto myself, so that I might finish my course with joy, and the ministry, which I have received of the Lord Jesus, to testify the gospel of the grace of God."*

How could he possibly maintain an attitude of victory in such a turbulent time in his life? I believe he let us in on the secret to his attitude of victory even though he knew he was staring death in the whites of the eyes. Listen to the first Four words he says to Agrippa, [Acts 26:2](#) *"I THINK MYSELF HAPPY..."*

Now please understand that I am aware that Paul was saying to Agrippa that he was "HAPPY" for the opportunity to finally tell his side of the story. However I believe that those Four words characterize the life and ministry of the Apostle Paul! He had Pastored and preached in places where he had to "THINK HIMSELF HAPPY" in order to continue on!

Paul practiced "THINKING HIMSELF HAPPY" to the point that he was able to say, [Philip. 4:11](#) *"... I have learned, in whatsoever state I am, therewith to be content."* This is a level in God most Christians never attain! You will never be "HAPPY" until you are content! To be content, you must be relaxed! To be relaxed you must be comfortable with the circumstances that surround your life! To be comfortable with your circumstances, you must believe you are in the will of God! The only way you can attain this level of comfort is to work on "THINKING YOURSELF HAPPY"!

Given the circumstances of his life, how could Paul be this "HAPPY"? He let us in on this secret three verses earlier:

[Philip. 4:8](#) *"Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is noble, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable--if anything is excellent or praiseworthy--think about such things."*

Please understand, this is not mind over matter, this is about girding up the loins of your mind, and controlling your thought life, so that the joy of the Lord can strengthen you!

It is possible, even in difficult circumstances, to "THINK YOURSELF HAPPY"! The Apostle Peter gives a three point outline on how to do just exactly that! [1 Peter 1:13](#)

"Wherefore gird up the loins of your mind, be sober, and hope to the end for the grace that is to be brought unto you at the revelation of Jesus Christ;"

According to the Apostle Peter if you are going to "THINK YOURSELF HAPPY" you must....

I. GIRD UP THE LOINS OF YOUR MIND!

II. BE SOBER!

III. HOPE TO THE END!

I. GIRD UP THE LOINS OF YOUR MIND!

A. The word "GIRD" as it is used here, comes from the Greek word "ANAZONNUMI" (an-ad-zone'-noo-mee), and means to gird afresh. This word comes from two other Greek words:

- "ANA" (an-ah'), which means to prop up by repetition.
- "ZONNUMI" (zone'-noo-mi), and means to bind about as with a belt.

Always remember, the battle will not be fought with boxing gloves of fisty-cuffs, but the real battle will be fought in your mind! It is here that the battle will be won or lost! **Romans 8:5-9** *"For they that are after the flesh do mind the things of the flesh; but they that are after the Spirit the things of the Spirit. For to be carnally minded is death; but to be spiritually minded is life and peace. Because the carnal mind is enmity against God: for it is not subject to the law of God, neither indeed can be. So then they that are in the flesh cannot please God. But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you. Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his."*

B. What the Apostle Peter is saying here is that it is up to us to control our own thought life. God is not going to do it for us, it is our responsibility to set a guard at the door of our mind! My mother used to say, *"you can't keep a bird from flying over your head, but you can keep him from building a nest in your hair"!*

We must "GIRD UP THE LOINS OF OUR MIND" in such a way that our thoughts will provoke the joy of the Lord in our lives. **Philip. 2:5** *"Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus:"*

Philip. 4:7-8 *"And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus. Finally, brethren, whatsoever things are true, whatsoever things are honest, whatsoever things are just, whatsoever things are pure, whatsoever things are lovely, whatsoever things are of good report; if there be any virtue,*

and if there be any praise, think on these things."

C. The only way you will ever be able to "THINK YOURSELF HAPPY" is by controlling your mind through repetition! That's why we sometimes sing songs like:

- Think about his love, think about his goodness, think about his grace, that's brought us through. For as high as the heavens above, so great is the measure of our Father's love. So great is the measure of our Father's love.
- When I think about his goodness and what he's done for me, I think about his goodness and how he's set me free... makes me praise... dance... jump... run... shout... all night!
- Look what the Lord has done. Look what the Lord has done. He healed my body, He touched my mind, He saved me just in time. I'm gonna praise his name, each day he's just the same, come on and praise him, look what the Lord has done!

When writing to his choir director, David said, **Psalm 39:1-3** *"I will take heed to my ways, that I sin not with my tongue: I will keep my mouth with a bridle, while the wicked is before me. ²I was dumb with silence, I held my peace, even from good; and my sorrow was stirred. ³My heart was hot within me, while I was musing the fire burned:..."*

David didn't just write about meditating on the works of God's hands until he "THOUGHT HIMSELF HAPPY", he actually practiced it! **Psalm 143:1-5** *"Hear my prayer, O Lord, give ear to my supplications: in thy faithfulness answer me, and in thy righteousness. ²And enter not into judgment with thy servant: for in thy sight shall no man living be justified. ³For the enemy hath persecuted my soul; he hath smitten my life down to the ground; he hath made me to dwell in darkness, as those that have been long dead. ⁴Therefore is my spirit overwhelmed within me; my heart within me is desolate. ⁵I remember the days of old; I meditate on all thy works; I muse on the work of thy hands."*

Notice how chapter 144 begins **Psalm 144:1-2** *"Blessed be the Lord my strength, which teacheth my hands to war, and my fingers to fight: ²My goodness, and my fortress; my high tower, and my deliverer; my shield, and he in whom I trust; who subdueth my people under me."*

Through controlling what he allowed his mind to "THINK" about, David actually "THOUGHT HIMSELF HAPPY" instead of sad! You and I can do the same!

You will either "THINK YOURSELF HAPPY", or you will "THINK YOURSELF SAD"! The decision is yours!

II. BE SOBER!

A. **1 Peter 1:13** *"Wherefore gird up the loins of your mind, be sober, and hope to the end for the grace that is to be brought unto you at the revelation of Jesus Christ;"*

The word "SOBER" comes from the Greek word "NEPHO" (nay'-fo), and means to abstain from wine. Be alert!

The Apostle Peter say's four chapters later, **1 Peter 5:8**

"Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil, as a roaring lion, walketh about, seeking whom he may devour:"

There is a major difference between the word "may" and the word "can". The word "may" denotes that he must get permission. The word "can" denotes he is able and does not need permission! I am here to inform you that while the devil "may" defeat you, he "cannot" unless you give him permission to do so!

Peter is saying that your ability to remain "SOBER" will directly affect your ability to win battles, and remain "HAPPY"!

B. You may be thinking, *"how could SOBRIETY affect my ability to THINK MYSELF HAPPY"?*

"SOBRIETY" is not the ability to frown or maintain a gruff exterior. "SOBRIETY" is not the denial of circumstances in a quest for "HAPPINESS"! The "SOBRIETY" that Peter was speaking of is a sane estimation of the circumstances that surround your life, coupled with a faith that GOD is bigger than the problem!

When you begin to look at your circumstances through God's looking glasses, it won't take you long to "THINK YOURSELF HAPPY"! (My experience studying for this message. I Couldn't see the numbers in the Strong's Concordance!)

If you are intoxicated by this world, and what it has to offer, your circumstances will never be good enough to make you truly "HAPPY"! In fact, your circumstances will get the best of you! Look at the Children of Israel: The men have gone into Caanan to look the land over. Caleb and Joshua come back believing they are able to conquer the land. Notice **Numbers 13:31-33**

"But the men that went up with him said, We be not able to go up against the people; for they are stronger than we. ³²And they brought up an evil report of the land which they had searched unto the children of Israel, saying, The land, through which we have gone to search it, is a land that eateth up the inhabitants thereof; and all the people that we saw in it are men of a great stature. ³³And there we saw the giants, the sons of Anak, which come of the giants: and we

were in our own sight as grasshoppers, and so we were in their sight."

The problem with these ten spies was they were still intoxicated by Egypt! Consequently, Caleb and Joshua were the only two from their generation allowed to possess the land! Why? **"THEY THOUGHT THEMSELVES HAPPY!"**

Do you want to live in the wilderness of doubt and unbelief, or do you want to express faith and confidence in GOD, and **"THINK YOURSELF HAPPY"?**

C. When you begin to **"SOBER"** up, and see it the way GOD sees it, you will surely **"THINK YOURSELF HAPPY"!**

In first grade we all read a book about a little train that was carrying a very heavy load. This little train was approaching a hill that seemed too steep to climb. As the little train approached the hill he could be heard to say ***"I think I can. I think I can. I think I can. I t-h-i-n-k I c-a-n. I t-h-i-n-k-- I c-a-n. I t---h---i---n---k I c---a---n."***

This little train did not deny the circumstances. He knew the hill was steep, and the load was heavy! What the little train knew, that bystanders were not aware of, was the power of his momentum, and the size of the engine in his locomotive!

When the little train topped the hill and began his decent, he could be heard saying, ***"I thought I could. I thought I could. I thought I could."*** The little train **"THOUGHT HIMSELF HAPPY"!** You can do the same!

You will either **"THINK YOURSELF HAPPY"**, or you will **"THINK YOURSELF SAD"!** The decision is yours!

III. HOPE TO THE END!

A. 1 Peter 1:13 ***"Wherefore gird up the loins of your mind, be sober, and hope to the end for the grace that is to be brought unto you at the revelation of Jesus Christ;"***

The NIV puts it like this: **1 Peter 1:13** ***"Therefore, prepare your minds for action; be self-controlled; set your hope fully on the grace to be given you when Jesus Christ is revealed."***

The word **"HOPE"** as it is used here, comes from the Greek word **"ELPIZO"** (el-pid'zo), and means to expect or trust.

The word **"END"** as it is used here, comes from the Greek word **"TELEIOS"** (tel-i'-oce), and means without wavering to completion.

"HOPE" is a must for the person who is determined to **"THINK THEMSELVES**

HAPPY". I want you to know that William Jefferson Clinton is not the only person that still believes in a place called "**HOPE**"! (NIV) **Hebrews 6:16-19** "*Men swear by someone greater than themselves, and the oath confirms what is said and puts an end to all argument. ¹⁷Because God wanted to make the unchanging nature of his purpose very clear to the heirs of what was promised, he confirmed it with an oath. ¹⁸God did this so that, by two unchangeable things in which it is impossible for God to lie, we who have fled to take hold of the hope offered to us may be greatly encouraged. ¹⁹We have this hope as an anchor for the soul, firm and secure. It enters the inner sanctuary behind the curtain,"*

B.1 Peter 1:13 "*Therefore, prepare your minds for action; be self-controlled; set your hope fully on the grace to be given you when Jesus Christ is revealed."*

The Apostle Peter is telling us here that if we are going to live a victorious, overcoming Christian life we must "**THINK OURSELVES HAPPY**" by focusing on the prize at the end of the race!

In building a house, the frame goes up quick and it's not too difficult to keep the morale up during this stage of construction. However, once this stage is complete things slow down and some day's it seem as though nothing at all was accomplished. It is during these times that you must keep the final product in focus!

This is true of the Christian life. You will meet with discouraging times and circumstances but you must never fail to "**HOPE TO THE END**"!

The writer of Hebrews gives us a little snapshot into what allowed Jesus to maintain a "**HAPPY**" attitude despite the fact that he knew what awaited him at the cross! (NIV) **Hebrews 12:2** "*Let us fix our eyes on Jesus, the author and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy set before him endured the cross, scorning its shame, and sat down at the right hand of the throne of God."* You see, Jesus forced himself to live beyond the betrayal, Pilates hall, the cross, descending into hell. He lived his life in anticipation of the day the grave would burst open; The day he would be able to walk through walls again; The day gravity would lose it's power over his body; The day he would be seated at the Father's right hand. Because of this, it didn't matter how bad the circumstances were, he was able to "**THINK HIMSELF HAPPY**"!

If you are going to "**THINK YOURSELF HAPPY**" you must develop a vision that is capable of leap-frogging your present circumstances!

Some people say I'm doing pretty well under the circumstances! Who gave you permission to get under the circumstances? God's word says that "*...the God of peace shall bruise satan under your feet shortly*".

C. How can we have the kind of “HOPE” that will cause us to “THINK OURSELVES HAPPY”? Paul said to the Roman church **Romans 15:4** *"For whatsoever things were written aforetime were written for our learning, that we through patience and comfort of the scriptures might have hope."*

At times it may seem impossible to “THINK YOURSELF HAPPY”, because of the circumstances. The ability to “THINK YOURSELF HAPPY” is based on three things; Patience! **Hebrews 10:35-36** *"Cast not away therefore your confidence, which hath great recompence of reward. ³⁶For ye have need of patience, that, after ye have done the will of God, ye might receive the promise."*

ILL: The dash between the dates. “I THINK MYSELF HAPPY”!

The Word of God! Pentecostal people are notorious for wanting to live on a fuzzy feeling. I like to shout and praise the Lord as much as the next person but I do not base my “HAPPINESS” on my feelings, but on the Word of God! **1 Peter 1:3** *"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, which according to his abundant mercy hath begotten us again unto a lively hope by the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead,"*

The Word of God say’s we are redeemed! That we are accepted! That we are victorious! That we will be glorified! That despite our suffering here, we will reign with our Lord! “I THINK MYSELF HAPPY”!

Keeping your focus on the end of the race! **1 John 3:1-3** *"Behold, what manner of love the Father hath bestowed upon us, that we should be called the sons of God: therefore the world knoweth us not, because it knew him not. ²Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is. ³And every man that hath this hope in him purifieth himself, even as he is pure."*

What are we “HOPING” for? **Rev. 22:12** *"And, behold, I come quickly; and my reward is with me, to give every man according as his work shall be."*

Romans 8:18 *"For I reckon that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory which shall be revealed in us."*

1 Cor. 15:51-58 "Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, ⁵²In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed. ⁵³For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality. ⁵⁴So when this corruptible shall have put on incorruption, and this mortal shall have put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written, Death is swallowed up in victory. ⁵⁵O death, where is thy sting? O grave, where is thy victory? ⁵⁶The sting of death is sin; and the strength of sin is the law. ⁵⁷But thanks be to God, which giveth us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ. ⁵⁸Therefore, my beloved brethren, be ye stedfast, unmovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, forasmuch as ye know that your labour is not in vain in the Lord."

1 Thes. 4:13-18 "But I would not have you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning them which are asleep, that ye sorrow not, even as others which have no hope. ¹⁴For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him. ¹⁵For this we say unto you by the word of the Lord, that we which are alive and remain unto the coming of the Lord shall not prevent them which are asleep. ¹⁶For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first: ¹⁷Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord. ¹⁸Wherefore comfort one another with these words."

CONCLUSION: I choose by an act of my own will to "THINK MYSELF HAPPY"!!!
Are you going to overflow with joy and be pleasant to be around, or are you going to be a sad sack that everyone dreads having to spend time with?

The decision is yours! "THINK YOURSELF HAPPY" for all of our sakes!!!

1st Assembly Malvern 5/21/2000 AM & PM
Cedar Grove A/G Hector, AR 6/22/2000
Christian Temple Houston, TX 2/2003
1st A/G Sheridan, AR 2/3/2004 Fellowship Mtg.